

Beyond the screen: The hidden truths of our social media lives

Social media is a tool to make life more connected and interesting, it is not a measure to judge worth and success of family and friends

Ever since social media **sneaked into** our lives, we have made it a **shelf** to display our lives' **wares**. We paint our digital walls with milestones, memories, smiles, and **sorrows**. It's a **vibrant collage** of life's **varied hues**, yet what we post is often a **curated** version of reality. The smiles are brighter, the love is deeper, the vacations are **grandier**, and the heartbreaks are more dramatic. But behind this **veneer** of filtered perfection, the raw and unfiltered truth **often lurks** quietly, hidden from the world's **gaze**.

For a month, I posted pictures from my holiday—**pristine landscapes**, **cheerful** meals, and stylish getups—giving the impression that I was the happiest and luckiest person on earth. From the outside, it looked like life was a **seamless tapestry** of joy and **contentment**. But behind each post was a personal battle being **waged** in silence. While my timeline **radiated unbridled** joy, I was working on myself to **remedy** a tough health challenge. Why did I choose to post happy pictures when my reality was **tumultuous**? Was I **pretending**? Was I seeking **validation**? No. I was trying to reassure myself. I was reminding myself that happiness exists, that moments of beauty and joy still **punctuate** my life. Those posts were not **deceit**; they were lifelines. **Glimpses** of joy that I **clung** to as I **navigated** the storm within. And in sharing those moments, I was also hoping to pass on **slivers of hope** to others who might be fighting unseen battles. This is the **duality** of social media.

The laughter we see might be **tears in disguise**. The grand celebrations could be **cloaked** in **anxiety**. The tears **shed** publicly may be **crafted** for effect. What appears authentic can be **artifice**; what looks carefree can be layered with burdens. This is why we should not judge others based on what we see on their profiles. Why do people **disguise** their struggles and present happy pictures? It's not necessarily deceit or a desire to **mislead** others.

Sometimes, it's a way of keeping hope alive. When life's challenges **weigh** heavily, **projecting** happiness can feel like a self-fulfilling **prophecy**. By sharing joy, even when it feels out of reach, we try to **manifest** it. We tell ourselves that happiness is not an **illusion**—it's **around the corner** and within our **grasp**. We also do it for others. Social media can be a dark and **overwhelming** place filled with negativity, comparison, and **distressing** news. By sharing moments of beauty, love and humour, we offer small doses of positivity to those who might need them. But herein lies the trap. When we view others' lives through the **glossy lens** of social media, we risk falling into the **pit** of comparison. We measure our own lives against the seemingly perfect lives of others and **wonder** where we went wrong.

We feel **envious**, **resentful**, or inadequate. But this comparison is unfair—because it's based on incomplete information. What you see on social media is a highlight reel, not a documentary. To compare your behind-the-scenes reality to someone else's carefully chosen highlights is to set yourself up for **needless** suffering. So, how should we approach social media with clarity and kindness? First,

partake in others' happiness without **envy**. Celebrate their joys as you would want them to celebrate yours.

Let their happiness be a reminder that good things are possible, even if they haven't yet arrived in your life. Second, **lend** support in difficult times without judgment. If someone shares their struggles, **resist** the urge to **undermine** or dismiss them. Behind their words could be a pain far deeper than what they've expressed. Offer **empathy**, not assumptions. Be the **steady** presence that reminds them they're not alone. Finally, take social media for what it is—a tool to make life more connected, more interesting and occasionally more fun. It's not a measure of worth, success, or happiness. **[Practice E.]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Sneak into** (phrasal verb) – Enter secretly, slip in, creep in चुपके से घुसना
2. **Shelf** (noun) – Platform, surface, ledge, display space दराज
3. **Ware** (noun) – Product, goods, item, merchandise सामान
4. **Sorrow** (noun) – Sadness, grief, anguish, pain दुःख/पीड़ा
5. **Vibrant** (adjective) – Bright, lively, vivid, energetic चमकीला/जीवंत
6. **Collage** (noun) – Collection, mixture, assemblage, composition मिश्रण/संग्रह
7. **Varied** (adjective) – Diverse, different, assorted, mixed अलग-अलग
8. **Hue** (noun) – Shade, color, tint, tone रंग
9. **Curated** (adjective) – Carefully selected, organized, arranged विचारपूर्वक चुना हुआ
10. **Grandeur** (adjective) – Bigger, more impressive, more magnificent विशाल
11. **Veneer** (noun) – Mask, facade, superficial layer, disguise झूठा दिखावा
12. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, regularly, repeatedly अक्सर
13. **Lurk** (verb) – Hide, remain unseen, loiter, creep छुपा होना/घात लगाना
14. **Gaze** (noun) – Look, stare, glance, focus नज़र/टकटकी
15. **Pristine** (adjective) – Pure, unspoiled, clean, untouched अछूता
16. **Landscape** (noun) – Scenery, view, panorama, terrain दृश्य
17. **Cheerful** (adjective) – Happy, joyful, pleasant, bright प्रसन्न
18. **Seamless** (adjective) – Smooth, continuous, flawless, uninterrupted बिना रुकावट
19. **Tapestry** (noun) – Rich, complex composition, intricate picture विस्तृत दृश्य
20. **Contentment** (noun) – Satisfaction, happiness, peace, ease संतोष
21. **Wage** (verb) – Carry on, fight, engage in, conduct लड़ाई लड़ना
22. **Radiate** (verb) – Emit, shine, exude, glow फैलाना
23. **Unbridled** (adjective) – Uncontrolled, unlimited, unchecked, free अनियंत्रित
24. **Remedy** (verb) – Fix, solve, treat, correct ठीक करना
25. **Tumultuous** (adjective) – Chaotic, turbulent, troubled, disorderly अशांत

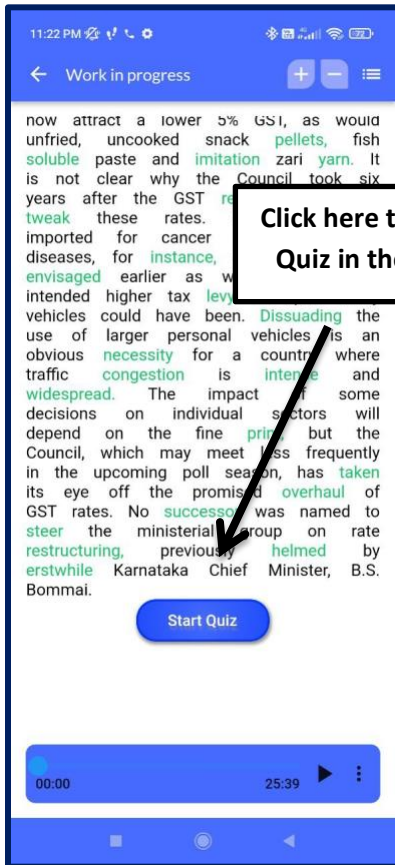
26. **Pretending** (adjective) – Feigning, acting, posing, imitating दिखावा करने वाला
27. **Validation** (noun) – Approval, confirmation, recognition, affirmation मान्यता
28. **Punctuate** (verb) – Interrupt, emphasize, highlight, mark टोकना
29. **Deceit** (noun) – Dishonesty, falsehood, trickery, fraud धोखा
30. **Glimpse** (noun) – Hint, quick look, insight, brief view झलक
31. **Clung** (to) (verb) – Hold on tightly, stick to, grip चिपके रहना
32. **Navigate** (verb) – Move through, manage, steer, find one's way रास्ता निकालना
33. **Sliver of hope** (phrase) – Small piece, slight chance, ray of hope छोटी सी उम्मीद
34. **Duality** (noun) – Two-sidedness, contrast, opposition दोहरी प्रकृति
35. **Tear in disguise** (phrase) – Hidden sadness, concealed sorrow छुपा हुआ दुःख
36. **Cloak** (verb) – Cover, hide, disguise, conceal छुपाना/आवरण देना
37. **Anxiety** (noun) – Worry, nervousness, unease, stress चिंता/व्याकुलता
38. **Shed** (verb) – Release, drop, cast off, let go बहाना/गिराना
39. **Craft** (verb) – Create, make, shape, design बनाना
40. **Artifice** (noun) – Trickery, deception, pretense, cunning चालाकी/छलावा
41. **Disguise** (verb) – Hide, conceal, cover up, mask छुपाना/वेश बदलना
42. **Mislead** (verb) – Deceive, fool, misinform, misguide भटकाना
43. **Weigh** (verb) – influence a decision or action बोझ डालना
44. **Project** (verb) – Display, present, show, portray प्रस्तुत करना
45. **Prophecy** (noun) – Prediction, forecast, foresight भविष्यवाणी
46. **Manifest** (verb) – Show clearly, display, prove, materialize प्रकट करना
47. **Illusion** (noun) – Misconception, false belief, mirage, fantasy भ्रम
48. **Around the corner** (phrase) – Nearby, close, about to happen निकट
49. **Grasp** (noun) – Understanding, hold, control, grip समझ
50. **Overwhelming** (adjective) – Intense, overpowering, immense, daunting अत्यधिक
51. **Distressing** (adjective) – Upsetting, painful, troubling, worrying पीड़ादायक

52. **Glossy** (adjective) – Shiny, attractive, polished, superficial आकर्षक
53. **Lens** (noun) – Perspective, view, focus, angle नजरिया
54. **Pit** (noun) – Hole, trap, low point, chasm खाई
55. **Wonder** (verb) – Question, think, ponder, marvel आश्चर्य करना
56. **Envious** (adjective) – Jealous, resentful, covetous, desirous ईर्ष्यालु
57. **Resentful** (adjective) – Angry, bitter, displeased, irritated नाराज
58. **Needless** (adjective) – Unnecessary, superfluous, avoidable, redundant अनावश्यक
59. **Partake** (verb) – Participate, share, join in, indulge भाग लेना
60. **Envy** (noun) – Jealousy, covetousness, resentment ईर्ष्या
61. **Lend** (verb) – Offer, provide, give, assist देना
62. **Resist** (verb) – Oppose, refrain, fight, hold back रोकना
63. **Undermine** (verb) – Weaken, erode, sabotage, diminish कमज़ोर करना
64. **Empathy** (noun) – Understanding, compassion, care, sensitivity सहानुभूति
65. **Steady** (adjective) – Constant, reliable, consistent, stable स्थिर

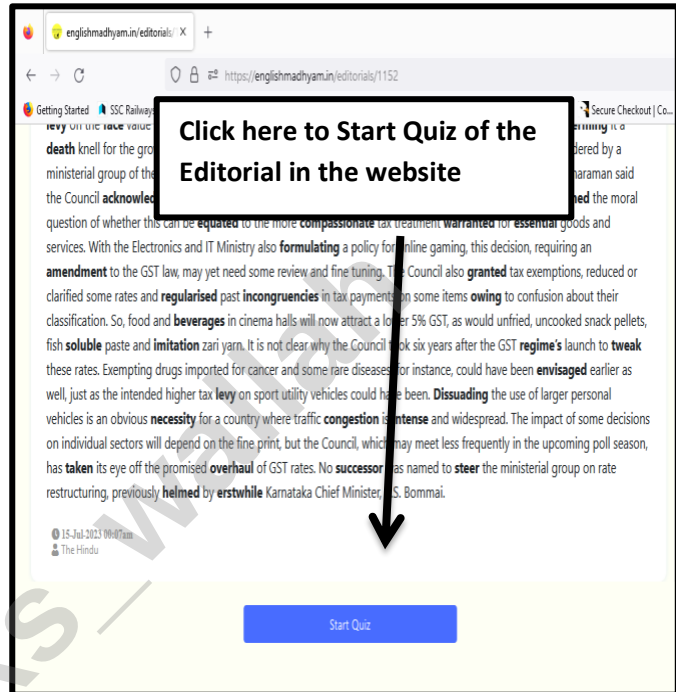
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Social Media as a Display Shelf:** Social media is a platform where people share curated versions of their lives, showcasing milestones, memories, and emotions.
2. **Filtered Reality:** Online profiles often highlight the best aspects of life, masking struggles behind carefully crafted posts.
3. **Personal Example:** The writer shares their experience of posting happy vacation pictures while privately dealing with a serious health challenge.
4. **Reason Behind Happy Posts:** Posting joyful moments during tough times can serve as a coping mechanism, offering personal reassurance and maintaining hope.
5. **Dual Nature of Social Media:** What appears happy can hide struggles; what seems authentic might be carefully constructed.
6. **Judgment-Free Perspective:** People should refrain from judging others based on social media appearances, as they reveal only selective aspects of life.
7. **Hope as Motivation:** Sharing positive experiences can be a way to inspire hope, both for oneself and others facing challenges.
8. **The Comparison Trap:** Social media fosters unhealthy comparisons, making people feel inadequate based on incomplete, idealized portrayals of others' lives.
9. **Highlight Reel vs. Reality:** Social media is a highlights reel, not a full account of anyone's life, leading to distorted perceptions of success and happiness.
10. **Approach with Kindness:** View others' posts with joy, not envy. Celebrate their happiness, even if life feels difficult for you.
11. **Offer Genuine Support:** Be empathetic and supportive when someone shares struggles online, recognizing the deeper issues that might lie beneath the surface.
12. **Avoid Assumptions:** Don't undermine or dismiss others' emotions; offer understanding instead.
13. **Social Media's True Purpose:** It should be used as a tool for connection, inspiration, and entertainment—not as a yardstick for measuring personal worth or success.
14. **Resist Negativity:** Avoid letting social media amplify negativity or feelings of inadequacy caused by constant comparison.
15. **Balanced Perspective:** Use social media mindfully, embracing its ability to connect and uplift while staying aware of its limitations in reflecting real life.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



Click here to Start Quiz in the App



Click here to Start Quiz of the Editorial in the website

[Click here to download App](#)

[Click here to visit website](#)



Learn Vocabulary Through Reading Articles

English Madhyam